Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

READING CHECK: "BISCUIT" AND "THE REEDS OF THE NORTH LAGOON"

Version A

Read the story and the article. Then answer each question. For multiple choice, fill in the circle next to the best answer. For the others, write on the lines.

Biscuit

Fiction · Written for this quiz.

1 Mrs. Abara handed Kiran her spare key and a page of notes. "Biscuit is shy with new people, so don't take it personally," she said. At the bottom she had written: Dev will come Thursday to water the plants. Kiran had asked his parents for a pet for three years. Four days with Biscuit felt like a test, and he planned to get a perfect score.

2 On Monday morning the apartment was silent. Kiran filled the bowl and crouched by the couch. "Here, kitty, kitty!" He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time. He walked to school with his shoulders up near his ears.

3 That evening the bowl was empty, and the blanket on the armchair was warm and covered in orange hair. Kiran looked behind the mat. Nothing had spilled. At dinner his sister Tam said, "So she ate!" Kiran shook his head. "Dev must have come by and tossed it out. She won't touch anything I give her."

4 On Tuesday he tried harder. He waved a feather toy under the bed and sang to her. Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away. "She misses Mrs. Abara too much to eat," he told Tam. "And she hates me." Tam shrugged. "Or you're loud."

5 On Wednesday evening Kiran had a math test to study for and no energy for singing. He sat on the floor against the couch, opened his notebook, and forgot to call her at all.

6 After a while, something warm leaned against his elbow. Biscuit sat beside him, staring at the page as if she were checking his work. Kiran did not reach for her. He kept writing, but slower. She stayed until he finished the last problem.

7 On Thursday, Dev was watering the plants when Mrs. Abara got home. She glanced at Kiran's notebook. "I used to teach math, you know." Kiran started to say, "She didn't eat at first," then looked at Dev and stopped. Biscuit was curled on the armchair, watching him. "Could I come over sometimes?" he asked. "I'd bring my homework."

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Questions 1-5: "Biscuit"

1. In paragraph 4, what does Tam think is the reason Biscuit stays away?

A. Biscuit misses Mrs. Abara and wants her back.

B. Kiran is making too much noise.

C. Biscuit is shy with every new person.

D. Biscuit has decided she does not like Kiran.

2. On Wednesday evening, why does Kiran most likely sit down on the floor against the couch?

A. He plans to stay quiet so that Biscuit will come out to him.

B. He is too worn out from singing to keep going.

C. He has schoolwork he needs to get done.

D. He hopes the feather toy he left by the couch will draw her out.

3. In paragraph 7, Kiran starts to say something to Mrs. Abara and then stops. What has he most likely just figured out?

A. Biscuit had eaten the Monday food herself.

B. Mrs. Abara came home early that day.

C. Dev was supposed to come by that day.

D. The bowl tipped over behind the mat.

4. Why does the author tell us, in paragraph 1, how long Kiran had been asking for a pet?

A. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a dull chore

B. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a test he means to ace

C. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a contest with Dev over who she likes best

D. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a skill he has already mastered

5. On Tuesday, what does Kiran try, and how does Biscuit respond? Quote the sentence that shows how she responds, and give its paragraph number.

Answer: _____

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The Reeds of the North Lagoon

Nonfiction · Written for this quiz. Vessa Island, its people and its animals are invented.

1 Vessa Island has two shallow lagoons, North and South, with a strip of sand between them. Tall tolla reeds grew thick along both shores. A long-legged gray bird called the drell nests only in thick reeds. At night it wades through the mud and eats kib snails.

2 In the winter of 1961, a storm flattened the reeds around the North Lagoon. The South Lagoon, behind higher dunes, lost only a few. With nowhere to nest, the North Lagoon's drells flew off. Some fishermen were glad. They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it.

3 Everyone expected the reeds to come back in a year or two, as they had after smaller storms. They did not. Each spring, green shoots poked up from the mud, and each summer they were gone. Islanders blamed the salt the storm had washed in.

4 In 1968, a teacher named Hana Selk tested the North Lagoon's water and found it no saltier than the South's. Then she went out after dark with a lamp. The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots. Without drells, almost nothing was eating the kibs.

5 The islanders first tried planting reeds by hand. The snails ate those too. So in 1971 Selk's students built wooden nesting platforms and hid them in the last reed clumps. Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring.

6 The change was slow. For five summers the shoots kept vanishing, and some islanders said the platforms were a waste of wood. By 1980, though, every platform was in use, the snails were thinner on the mud, and reeds stood again along the North Lagoon's shore.

7 The fishermen's catch did not drop when the drells came back. If anything, it rose. Young fish hide among reed stems.

8 Selk later wrote, "The storm knocked the reeds down. The missing birds kept them down."

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Questions 6-10: "The Reeds of the North Lagoon"

6. According to the article, who first found out what was happening to the new shoots?

A. Tomas Brill, a fisherman

B. a group of students

C. Hana Selk, a teacher

D. a scientist from the mainland

7. Why did the South Lagoon most likely keep most of its reeds in the 1961 storm?

A. It sat behind higher land that blocked the storm.

B. Thick reeds broke up the waves first.

C. Tougher reeds grew on that shore.

D. Rain and wind missed that side of the island.

8. Based on the article, why did the North Lagoon's reeds stay away after 1961, when they had come back after smaller storms?

A. This storm left salt in the water that never washed out.

B. This storm spoiled the mud the old roots grew in.

C. This storm left the new shoots with no shelter from the cold.

D. This storm drove off the birds the new shoots depended on.

9. In paragraph 5, the islanders' first plan for the North Lagoon does not work. What does the author want readers to understand from that?

A. New reeds would not last until the salt washed out.

B. New reeds would not last until young fish stopped nibbling the roots.

C. New reeds would not last until fishermen stopped trampling the shore.

D. New reeds would not last until fewer snails were left to eat them.

10. What does "thinner" mean as it is used in paragraph 6? Quote a sentence from an earlier paragraph that helps show the meaning, and give its paragraph number.

Answer: _____

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (4 points)

Write your answer on the lines.

11. How does Kiran change from the beginning of "Biscuit" to the end? Use RACE: R - Restate the question. A - Answer it. C - Cite two pieces of evidence with [paragraph numbers]. E - Explain how each piece of evidence proves your answer.

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